Incident Report

Phishing: Fake Courier Redelivery Fee (Simulated Incident)

Incident ID	NR-2026-0001	**Severity**	Medium
Organisation	Nova Retail Pvt Ltd (fictional online retailer, Hyderabad)	**Status**	Closed
Incident type	Phishing (credential and payment lure)	**Detection source**	Email phishing detection system (Python)
Report author	Vishnu Vardhan, SOC Analyst (practice scenario)	**Report date**	19 Oct 2026

1. Executive Summary

An employee in the Finance team received an email posing as a courier company, claiming a parcel delivery had failed and asking for a Rs. 49 redelivery fee through a link. The phishing detection system flagged the email within a minute of delivery with a high risk score. The employee opened the link before the alert was reviewed but entered no card or login details. The email was removed from all mailboxes, the domain was blocked, and no data loss or account compromise was found.

2. Timeline (IST)

Time	Event
10:02	Email delivered to Employee A (Finance) from a spoofed courier sender.
10:03	Detection system scores the email 85/100 (High) and raises a desktop alert and a dashboard entry.
10:06	Employee A opens the link. The page imitates a payment form; no data is submitted.
10:15	SOC analyst reviews the alert and starts the investigation.
10:32	Headers, links and domain reputation analysed. Email confirmed as phishing.
10:45	Email removed from all mailboxes; domain blocked at the web filter and mail gateway.
11:10	Employee A contacted, password reset as a precaution, session tokens revoked.
11:40	Mail logs searched: 6 other staff received the email, 0 others opened the link. Incident closed.

3. Technical Analysis

Why the email was flagged. The rule-based scoring added points for each of these signs:

- Sender display name said "Nova Courier Support" but the sending domain was unrelated to any real courier.
- Urgent wording ("act today", "parcel will be returned") and a small payment request, a common lure.
- The link text did not match the real destination, and the domain was newly registered.
- Domain reputation check returned a malicious verdict (simulated result).

Indicators of compromise (defanged so they cannot be clicked):

Type	Value	Note
Sender	`support@nova-courier-delivery[.]example`	Spoofed courier sender
URL	`hxxps://redelivery-fee-pay[.]example/pay`	Fake payment page

Type	Value	Note
Domain	`redelivery-fee-pay[.]example`	Blocked at web filter
Sending IP	`192.0.2.45`	Documentation address (fictional)
Subject	`Delivery failed: pay Rs. 49 to reschedule`	Used to search all mailboxes

MITRE ATT&CK mapping: T1566.002 Phishing: Spearphishing Link (initial access) and T1204.001 User Execution: Malicious Link.

4. Impact Assessment

- **Confidentiality:** no evidence of exposed data; the employee did not submit any details.
- **Integrity and availability:** no systems changed and no downtime.
- **Reach:** 7 recipients in total, 1 opened the link.
- **Rating:** Medium, because a link was opened and the lure targeted Finance, but there was no compromise.

5. Containment, Eradication and Recovery

Phase	Action
Containment	Quarantined the email in all 7 mailboxes; blocked the domain and sender; warned the Finance team.
Eradication	Checked Employee A's device for downloads or new processes; none found. Cleared browser session data.
Recovery	Reset Employee A's password, revoked sessions, confirmed normal sign-in activity for 24 hours.

6. Lessons Learned and Recommendations

- Run short phishing awareness sessions for Finance, focused on delivery and payment lures.
- Enable link rewriting or sandboxing at the mail gateway so newly registered domains are checked on click.
- Keep the detection rules, and add a rule for small-payment lures such as redelivery fees.
- Add a one-click "Report phishing" button to the mail client so alerts reach the SOC faster.
- Require multi-factor authentication on all staff accounts to limit damage if details are ever entered.

This is a simulated incident written for portfolio practice. Nova Retail Pvt Ltd, the domains, IP address, scores and timings are fictional.